

3-2

Name: Trent Potter

Date: 3/2 12:00PM

No presentation Name

Summary

Trent Potter is a University of Kansas alum who talked about his career path from computer science undergraduate to professional high-frequency trader. He began his career with an internship at Amazon, where he worked on ad targeting and big data. He emphasized that this experience was for understanding how distributed systems scale and for recognizing the impact of management quality (this was a recurring theme in his advice). His senior year, he worked at a startup which tried to streamline the interview process for computer science students. Though the project ultimately hit a wall due to the COVID-19 pandemic, he highlighted the venture as an invaluable learning experience that taught him the realities of product development, pitching to investors, and truly understanding customer needs. He then worked at Google, where he worked remotely on ad measurement systems during the pandemic. While he gained exposure to massive, world-class internal databases, he found the pace and structure of a large corporation less fulfilling than he had hoped. Looking for something faster and more competitive, he got a job in trading. In order to get this job, he had to self-study statistics, convex optimization, and financial theory using free resources from MIT and Stanford. After a period in the trading industry, he pursued an MBA, where he further branched out into logistics product management and venture capital, specifically focusing on the intersection of technical merit and startup investment.

Currently, the speaker works in high-frequency trading, where he utilizes high-performance C++ and machine learning to manage complex trade books. He described the work as a fast-paced, high-stakes environment comparable to competitive gaming, where latency and mathematical precision are paramount. To end his presentation, he offered practical advice to the students in attendance: prioritize building strong technical systems, seek out supportive managers who invest in your professional development, and do not fear the high-risk, high-reward nature of startup environments. He concluded by positioning himself as an accessible resource for the class, encouraging them to reach out for guidance on interviewing, industry navigation, or technical development as they prepare to enter the workforce.

What I learnt

The most important thing I learned from the speaker is that a career in computer science is rarely a straight line, and success often comes from being proactive outside of the classroom. He showed us that while technical skills are the foundation, the ability to pivot (in his case it was

from a big tech internship at Amazon to a senior design startup, and then again into high-frequency trading) is what defines a career. I liked his advice on the "fat-tailed" nature of startups and trading; these fields offer massive growth and learning opportunities if you're willing to embrace the intensity and the risk of failure.

I also learned that the traditional curriculum might not cover everything needed for specialized roles. For example, he had to teach himself advanced statistics and convex optimization through MIT open courses to break into trading. His focus on finding a supportive manager who actually invests in your growth was a practical takeaway I hadn't considered before. Moving forward, I feel more encouraged to explore "non-CS" roles like product management or venture capital, knowing that a technical background is a huge competitive advantage in those spaces.

What I will do differently

Based on the talk, I'm going to change how I approach my professional development by being much more intentional about my "manager fit" during interviews. I used to focus only on the company name, but now I'll be looking for a mentor who will actually invest in my growth. I also plan to supplement my KU coursework with specialized self-study; since the speaker mentioned the importance of statistics and convex optimization for trading, I'll look into MIT courses to bridge those gaps. Finally, I'm going to treat my senior design project as a legitimate startup opportunity rather than just a graduation requirement to build those pitching and product management skills.